

IF I WERE HIM



A Novelette By Mehtab Hassan

If I Were Him

*In this city, success is not a dream.
It is an expectation.
And expectations are heavier than hunger.*

I did become someone they recognized. My name was spoken carefully in rooms where voices usually carried confidence. I wore the right clothes, said the right things, and learned how to look unbothered by numbers that once terrified me. From the outside, it looked like success, clean, earned, inevitable. But there are nights when the city lights feel heavier than darkness, when silence is louder than hunger ever was. People assume the story ends when you finally arrive. They don't see what's missing by then. This is not the story of how I won. It's the story of what I traded away to stand where I am now.

ACT I
WANTING

Graduation happened on a humid afternoon, the kind that makes you question why anyone decided fabric should touch skin at all. By the time it was over, nothing had changed except the way people spoke to me. The city remained expensive. The trains remained crowded. The future remained vague. But suddenly, everyone expected me to have answers.

I did not attend a ceremony. There were no hats thrown into the air, no dramatic applause, no photographs that would later pretend to represent accomplishment. My degree arrived quietly in an envelope that felt lighter than the years it claimed to summarize. I placed it on the table, straightened it once, and then left it there, as if proximity alone would make it useful. My mother looked at it with care, the way people look at things they don't fully understand but still respect. My father nodded once, satisfied in the way men are when a task reaches its official conclusion. University was done. What came next, according to them, was obvious.

It was not obvious to me.

Hong Kong does not celebrate endings. It only acknowledges movement. If you are moving forward, you are tolerated. If you pause, the city steps around you without apology. From our apartment window, buildings stood close together, their windows lit unevenly like a scoreboard no one explained. Somewhere inside those towers were people who knew where they were going. I watched them the way one watches traffic, aware it exists, unsure how to enter without getting hurt.

The first week after graduation was polite. Relatives called. Distant uncles offered advice that sounded like recycled newspaper columns. *"Opportunities are everywhere"* one of them said, confidently unemployed for the last three years. Another suggested I consider overseas options, as if geography alone could substitute preparation, money, and luck. I thanked them all. Gratitude is easier than explanation.

By the second week, the questions changed tone.

"So, any interviews yet?"

"Have you sent your CV?"

"You should not wait too long, you know."

Waiting, apparently, was a moral failure.

I began sending applications the way people send apologies they don't fully mean, quickly, carefully, and with lowered expectations. The job portals all looked the same, just different shades of optimism. Every listing asked for experience I did not have, confidence I was still borrowing,

and enthusiasm that felt dishonest to fake. I adjusted my CV daily, changing verbs, rearranging bullet points, hoping the right combination of words might unlock something invisible.

Nothing unlocked.

The rejection emails were impressively efficient. Some arrived within hours, others took days, as if consideration itself was part of the performance. Most began with *"Thank you for your interest"* which was comforting in the way automated kindness usually is. A few ended with *"We will keep your resume on file,"* which I learned to translate as *"Please do not wait."* I did not reply. There is dignity in knowing when a conversation is already over.

My parents did not pressure me directly. That would have required confrontation, and confrontation is exhausting. Instead, they asked small questions at inconvenient times. My father would mention a former colleague's son who had *"already started something promising."* My mother would remind me to wake early, as if discipline alone could summon opportunity. At dinner, they spoke about groceries and utility bills with careful neutrality, numbers hanging in the air like accusations no one voiced.

I started spending more time outside. Not purposefully, just away. The city offered plenty of places to exist without belonging. Coffee shops filled with people pretending to work. Libraries where ambition whispered instead of shouted. Trains where everyone stared forward, united by the unspoken agreement not to look at each other too closely. I carried my laptop with me, opened it in public spaces, and applied to jobs with the seriousness of someone performing effort.

Somewhere in those weeks, without ceremony, Victor Kwan entered my thoughts.

His name was impossible to avoid. It appeared in headlines, business forums, panel discussions, casual conversations among people who had never met him but spoke as if they had been personally inspired. Victor Kwan, the self-made billionaire. Victor Kwan, the man who started with nothing. Victor Kwan, proof that the system was fair, if you were exceptional enough.

I did not admire him loudly. Admiration felt too childish, too obvious. Instead, I observed. I read interviews where he spoke about discipline and sacrifice, about risk taken at the right moment. He spoke calmly, confidently, like someone who had already won and did not need to convince anyone anymore. People listened. People always listen to men who have reached the top and are generous enough to explain how simple it was.

At first, Victor was just a reference point. A story used to motivate graduates and justify inequality. But slowly, he became something else. A quiet measurement. A comparison I did not ask for but could not turn off. When a rejection arrived, I wondered how many he had received before someone said yes. When rent prices increased again, I wondered when money stopped being a concern for him. When my father sighed at the end of a long day, I wondered if Victor's father had ever done the same.

These were not healthy thoughts. I knew that. But they were persistent, and persistence often disguises itself as realism.

I eventually landed interviews. A few. Enough to feel temporarily validated. Offices with clean floors and polite smiles. Interviewers who nodded at the right moments and asked the same questions in different voices. *"Where do you see yourself in five years?"* they asked, genuinely curious about my capacity for imagination. I gave reasonable answers. I spoke about growth, contribution, alignment. I did not mention fear. Fear rarely aligns with corporate vision.

One interview ended with a handshake that lingered just long enough to suggest possibility. I left the building lighter than I had entered, already rehearsing how I would tell my parents. The email arrived the next morning. *"We regret to inform you..."* I deleted it without finishing the sentence. Some disappointments deserve efficiency.

By the end of the first month, my savings had begun to look nervous. I started calculating days instead of weeks. My parents noticed, of course. They always did. My mother began cooking slightly more than necessary. My father stopped mentioning other people's children. Silence adjusted itself around us, careful and deliberate.

One evening, while scrolling through yet another article praising Victor Kwan's latest acquisition, I caught my reflection in the darkened screen. It startled me, not because I looked different, but because I looked unchanged. Same face. Same uncertainty. Same quiet sense of being late to something everyone else had already started.

That was when the thought formed clearly, without disguise or apology.

If I were him, this would not be happening.

Not as a wish. Not as fantasy. Just as a statement. If I were him, doors would open. If I were him, silence would mean power, not absence. If I were him, my parents would sleep better. If I were him, this city would not feel like it was constantly testing me.

I closed the laptop. The room felt smaller than usual, the walls closer, the air heavier. Outside, the city continued doing what it always did, moving forward, indifferent and efficient. I sat there longer than necessary, aware of something shifting quietly inside me. Not hope. Not despair. Something more dangerous.

Comparison.

I did not know it yet, but this was the beginning of a transaction. Nothing had been signed. No choices had been made. But the question had entered my life, and questions like this do not leave politely. They wait. They grow. They ask again.

And Hong Kong, patient as ever, waited with it.

There is a specific kind of loneliness that only appears after graduation. It isn't dramatic. No crying in the bathroom, no late-night confessions. It is quieter than that, and therefore harder to explain. It feels like standing on a platform while trains keep arriving and leaving, all of them full, all of them going somewhere specific. You are not lost. You are just... not included.

I started measuring time differently. Not by days or weeks, but by other people's progress. One friend announced a new job on social media, complete with a carefully chosen caption about gratitude and growth. Another moved into a smaller apartment closer to work, which somehow sounded like a promotion even though it meant less space. Someone else posted a photograph of an office ID card, the company logo conveniently visible. I learned to like these posts quickly and without hesitation. Hesitation looks like jealousy, and jealousy is socially unacceptable unless disguised as motivation.

The truth was simpler. I was tired.

Every morning, I left the apartment with purpose I had to manufacture. I sat in public spaces and watched people who looked certain. Not happy, certainty and happiness rarely travel together, but settled. They walked faster, spoke with confidence, complained about work in a way that suggested belonging. Even their dissatisfaction felt earned. Mine felt premature.

Hong Kong made sure I noticed the difference. Rent prices climbed without explanation. Advertisements promised lifestyles I could not yet afford. Cafés filled with people discussing investments and side projects, conversations casual but calculated. The city had a talent for reminding you where you stood, even when you did not ask.

At home, my parents maintained a careful balance. They did not scold. They did not push. That would have been easier to resist. Instead, they trusted me in a way that felt heavy. My mother would ask if I had eaten, then pause, then ask if I had heard back from anyone. My father began reading the business section more intently, occasionally pointing out companies that were *"expanding."* I nodded, stored the information, and did nothing with it.

At night, I scrolled. Not aimlessly, deliberately. News, forums, profiles, opinions. I learned more about people I had never met than about myself. Victor Kwan appeared often, sometimes directly, sometimes as a reference. *"The next Victor Kwan."* *"Inspired by Victor Kwan."* *"What Victor Kwan did differently."* His name had become shorthand for possibility, proof that the ceiling was real but breakable, if you hit it hard enough and survived the fall.

I told myself I was studying. Learning. Preparing. This was partially true. Preparation can be an excuse, but it can also be a shield. It keeps you from acting too soon, from failing publicly. I was very good at preparing.

One afternoon, I ran into a former classmate by accident. We exchanged the usual greetings, the polite evaluation of each other's appearance. He asked what I was doing now. I told him I was "exploring options." He smiled and told me about his new role, the long hours, the steep learning curve. He complained briefly, out of courtesy. Then he checked his phone and said he had to go. We shook hands again. As he walked away, I noticed he did not look back.

I stood there longer than necessary, pretending to reply to a message that did not exist.

It wasn't that I felt inferior. Inferiority implies a clear hierarchy, and nothing in my life felt that organized. What I felt was misaligned, like I had followed the rules but missed an instruction

everyone else received quietly. I had the degree. I had the discipline. I even had ambition, though it was still theoretical. What I lacked was momentum, and momentum, I was learning, mattered more than intent.

That night, Victor Kwan appeared in an interview on my screen again. Older than I expected. Calmer. He spoke about timing, about recognizing opportunity before others did. He said something about risk that sounded brave and reasonable at the same time. I wondered, briefly, how many safety nets he had mistaken for courage. The thought surprised me. It was the first time admiration cracked into skepticism.

But the crack did not grow. Not yet.

Instead, the comparison sharpened. I began using Victor as a reference without meaning to. When I hesitated, I imagined how quickly he would have decided. When I doubted myself, I wondered if doubt had ever slowed him down. This was unfair, of course. To both of us. But fairness is rarely part of internal dialogue.

A week later, I received an offer.

It was not impressive. The salary was low enough to feel insulting but high enough to be practical. The role was vaguely defined, which meant flexibility, which meant exploitation if one were honest. Still, it was something. A place to go in the morning. A title to answer with when asked. A reason to stop explaining.

My parents were relieved. Not excited, relief is quieter, more controlled. My mother smiled and said it was a good start. My father nodded and asked about growth opportunities. I told them what they wanted to hear. I told myself the same.

On my first day, I wore clothes that tried very hard to look confident. The office was clean, neutral, efficient. People introduced themselves quickly and forgot my name just as fast. I listened more than I spoke. Listening is a survival skill in new hierarchies. By the end of the day, I was tired in a way that felt legitimate. Earned. I went home and slept without scrolling.

Over the next weeks, I learned how things actually worked. Effort was expected, gratitude was optional, and recognition arrived only after visibility. People stayed late not because they were told to, but because leaving early suggested replaceability. Meetings extended without purpose. Decisions were made elsewhere. I adapted quickly. Adaptation is another word for obedience when framed correctly.

The pay covered necessities. Barely. Rent still loomed. Savings remained fragile. But the rhythm helped. Routine has a way of dulling questions, at least temporarily. I stopped thinking about Victor Kwan every day. Only most days.

Then, during a meeting that could have been an email, someone mentioned him casually. Not with reverence, more like familiarity. *"Kwan would never approve this,"* they said, confidently. The name hung in the air. No explanation followed. None was needed.

It struck me then how proximity worked. How names gained power simply by being used often enough. Victor Kwan was no longer a distant myth. He was a benchmark, a shadow, a presence that shaped decisions without entering the room. I wondered how long it took to become that. How many compromises turned a person into a reference point.

On my way home that evening, standing shoulder to shoulder with strangers on the train, I felt something settle inside me. Not motivation. Not hunger. Recognition.

This city did not reward effort. It rewarded alignment. With power. With momentum. With people who already mattered.

The question returned, quieter but heavier than before.

If I were him, none of this would feel temporary.

I did not answer it. I did not need to. Some questions are not meant to be answered immediately. They are meant to follow you, shape your choices, wait patiently while you convince yourself you are still in control.

The train doors opened. People moved. I moved with them.

Hong Kong, as always, did not wait.

The first compromise never announces itself. It doesn't arrive with drama or guilt or the feeling that something irreversible has just occurred. It arrives disguised as practicality. Sensible. Almost responsible. If you hesitate, people look at you the way adults look at children who ask unnecessary questions.

By the third month at work, I had learned which hours mattered and which ones only pretended to. Mornings were for appearing alert. Afternoons were for performing urgency. Evenings were where decisions quietly moved. I stayed late without being asked, not because I enjoyed it, but because leaving on time felt like a statement I wasn't ready to make. No one praised the effort. They simply noticed when it stopped.

My role remained unclear, which turned out to be useful. Ambiguity meant flexibility, and flexibility meant availability. I did what needed to be done before anyone formally assigned it to me. This was interpreted as initiative. It was mostly fear, but fear is an acceptable substitute for ambition if you dress it correctly.

One evening, my manager asked me to stay back. He said it casually, as if he were asking about dinner plans. He had a way of making requests sound optional while making refusal feel unwise. We sat in a meeting room that smelled faintly of disinfectant and long hours. He spoke about restructuring, about how certain decisions needed to be handled delicately. There were things, he explained, that could not be communicated too directly.

He slid a document across the table. It wasn't illegal. It wasn't even unethical in a way that could be easily named. It was simply selective. Information arranged to suggest one conclusion while quietly discouraging another. *"We need this to move forward,"* he said. *"Everyone does it."*

Everyone always does it. That phrase carries an impressive amount of authority.

I hesitated just long enough for him to notice. He smiled, not unkindly. *"You're smart,"* he added, as if intelligence naturally led to agreement. *"You understand how this works."*

I did understand. That was the problem.

I signed off on it. Not dramatically. Just a signature. A small adjustment. Reasonable. Necessary. The kind of thing you stop thinking about almost immediately because thinking about it too long would require explanation.

On the way home, I waited for guilt to arrive. It didn't. Instead, there was a strange calm, like the quiet after a decision has already been made for you. The city looked the same. The buildings didn't collapse. My parents slept without worry. Nothing happened, which felt like confirmation.

That night, I slept well.

The next week, my manager treated me differently. Not better, just differently. He included me in conversations that were previously closed. He asked my opinion and listened as if it mattered. People noticed. They always do. Attention moves faster than merit.

With attention came responsibility. With responsibility came expectation. I was careful, efficient, and increasingly silent. Silence, I discovered, was a form of professionalism. You could say very little and still appear informed, provided you spoke at the right moments. I practiced this skill quietly. It came naturally.

My parents noticed changes before I did. My father commented that I seemed *"more settled."* My mother said I looked tired but proud. Both observations were accurate, though I would not have phrased them that way. I stopped explaining my work. Not because it was confidential, but because explanation invited questions I didn't want to answer.

Money improved slightly. Not enough to feel free, but enough to breathe. I paid my share of the rent without calculation. I bought small things without guilt. These changes felt significant. They were, in their own modest way. Progress is convincing when it arrives incrementally.

Victor Kwan appeared again around this time, though I hadn't been looking for him. A colleague mentioned an event he would be attending. Someone else joked about how different things would be if Kwan were in the room. The way they spoke about him had shifted. Less awe. More familiarity. As if success, once observed up close, lost some of its mythology and became a standard to meet.

I wondered if this was how it began. Not with hunger, but with proximity. Not with envy, but with understanding the rules.

One afternoon, I was asked to revise a report. The changes were subtle but intentional. Certain risks were downplayed. Certain benefits emphasized. It was presented as alignment, not deception. I made the revisions without hesitation. This time, there was no pause. No internal debate. The efficiency surprised me.

That evening, on the train ride home, I caught my reflection again. It looked the same as before, which was reassuring. Change, when it happens too visibly, invites concern. This change was internal. Invisible. Perfectly manageable.

I thought about Victor then, not with admiration or skepticism, but with something closer to understanding. Perhaps this was how he had done it. Not through grand betrayals or dramatic sacrifices, but through a series of reasonable adjustments. Each one small enough to ignore, together large enough to transform a life.

The thought did not disturb me. It made sense.

At home, my parents were watching the news. Victor Kwan's name appeared briefly, attached to another achievement. My mother commented that he must work very hard. My father nodded. I said nothing. There was nothing to add.

Later that night, I opened my laptop and reviewed my finances. The numbers were modest but stable. Stability had a comforting weight. It made other concerns feel theoretical. I closed the laptop and sat in the dark for a while, listening to the city outside. Traffic, voices, movement. Life continuing, indifferent and efficient.

I realized then that something had shifted. Not dramatically. Not enough to alarm anyone. But enough that the question I once asked, *If I were him*, no longer felt hypothetical. It felt directional. Like a path that had already begun to form beneath my feet.

I didn't know where it would lead. I didn't need to. The city rewards those who keep moving, not those who ask why.

I turned off the light and went to sleep, already adjusting.

ACT II

BECOMING

Every system insists it is fair. That is how it protects itself. If the rules were visible, people would question them. So instead, they are taught quietly, through tone, timing, and consequence. By the time you understand them, you are already participating.

I started noticing patterns. Who spoke first in meetings. Who spoke last. Whose ideas were repeated by someone else and suddenly taken seriously. Credit did not belong to those who worked hardest, but to those who arrived at the right moment with the right expression. Competence was assumed. Visibility had to be earned.

I learned when to nod. When to remain neutral. When to agree without committing. It wasn't manipulation. That word suggests intention. This was adaptation. The body adjusting to temperature.

Lunches became strategic. Sitting with the right people mattered more than eating well. Conversations circled around safe topics, markets, growth, vague complaints about workload. Personal details were exchanged carefully, like currency. Too much intimacy looked unprofessional. Too little looked cold. Balance was everything.

My manager began trusting me with context instead of tasks. Context is more dangerous. It makes you feel included. It also makes you complicit. I listened, absorbed, and responded with measured interest. I asked questions that demonstrated engagement without curiosity. This was appreciated.

The first time I stayed past midnight without resentment surprised me. I noticed it only because the security guard nodded at me differently on the way out. Recognition does not always come from those above you. Sometimes it comes from those who watch quietly and notice patterns.

At home, my parents adjusted to my absence. Dinner waited less often. My mother reheated food without comment. My father stopped asking about my schedule. These changes were framed as understanding. They were also distance, growing politely.

I told myself this was temporary. Everything ambitious pretends to be temporary.

Victor Kwan felt closer now, not in presence but in relevance. His name appeared less in headlines and more in internal conversations. Case studies. Comparisons. Benchmarks. I realized something uncomfortable then: people did not want to become Victor. They wanted to **be near** him. Proximity to power mattered more than imitation.

That was when I understood why success often looked empty from the outside. It was crowded on the way up.

One evening, I was invited to an informal gathering. Drinks, nothing serious. Informal gatherings are never informal. I went anyway. I listened more than I spoke. Someone mentioned a deal that had gone wrong. Someone else corrected the narrative gently. I said nothing, but I remembered both versions.

Later, someone asked my opinion. Not because it was needed, but because silence eventually becomes suspicious. I responded carefully, aligning with the direction already chosen. The response was met with approval. Subtle, but real.

On the way home, I thought about how easy that had been. How natural. How little resistance I had felt. This should have bothered me more than it did.

At work, responsibilities accumulated without announcement. I was trusted with follow-ups, coordination, decisions that required discretion. Trust, I learned, was not about morality. It was about predictability. I had become predictable.

My salary adjusted upward. Slightly. Enough to notice. Enough to justify the hours. Enough to make dissent feel expensive. I updated my budget and smiled without meaning to.

One night, while waiting for a document to upload, I caught myself defending a decision I would have questioned months earlier. I didn't raise my voice. I didn't argue passionately. I simply explained why it made sense. Everyone nodded. The matter closed.

That was the moment I understood how people changed without realizing it. Not by abandoning values, but by redefining them. Words like *"necessary," "practical,"* and *"inevitable"* did the work quietly.

I thought of Victor Kwan again. Not as an idol. Not as a warning. But as a conclusion.

If this was the path, then this was how he must have walked it. Calmly. Logically. Surrounded by people who understood the rules and never wrote them down.

I went home late. The city lights looked indifferent as ever. Somewhere between the office and my apartment, I realized I no longer asked whether I should continue. I only wondered how far this could go.

That question did not feel dangerous.

That worried me, briefly.

Then I slept.

There is a difference between knowing about power and standing near it. From a distance, it looks deliberate, composed, almost elegant. Up close, it smells like fatigue and calculation. I learned this gradually, the way people learn about weather, by being caught in it long enough.

The invitation arrived without drama. A networking event, phrased carefully as an opportunity, hosted in a building I had only ever seen from the outside. The message mentioned a few names,

one of which I recognized immediately. Victor Kwan would be present. Not speaking. Just attending. The word *present* did more work than any description could.

I told myself it didn't matter. That this was just another room, another conversation, another chance to appear competent. But I chose my clothes more carefully than usual. I arrived early. These details were not accidental.

The room was well-lit and deliberately uncomfortable, too clean, too quiet, designed to keep people alert. Conversations formed and dissolved quickly. Everyone was polite. Everyone was evaluating. I moved carefully, aware of where I stood and who noticed. When Victor Kwan entered, nothing dramatic happened. No applause. No announcement. Just a subtle shift, like air pressure changing.

He looked smaller than I expected. Not physically, just conceptually. Less myth, more man. Calm, efficient, surrounded by people who laughed slightly too quickly at his remarks. He spoke little. When he did, people leaned in. Attention gathered around him without effort. That, I realized, was the real achievement.

I did not speak to him. I did not need to. Proximity was enough. Listening was enough. I watched how others behaved near him, careful, deferential, eager to be useful without appearing desperate. It was familiar. I recognized myself in them more than I wanted to.

At one point, someone mentioned a project I had worked on. Victor nodded, mildly interested. "*That makes sense,*" he said. Just that. No praise. No critique. The conversation moved on. The comment should have meant nothing. It didn't.

On the way home, the city felt quieter than usual. Or maybe I was quieter. I replayed the evening, not with excitement, but with analysis. Victor was not extraordinary. He was disciplined. Surrounded. Protected by systems he had helped build. The realization was oddly disappointing. And yet, the pull remained.

At work, things shifted subtly after that night. People referenced the event. My name appeared in conversations it hadn't before. I was asked to attend more meetings, included in planning earlier. Nothing was promised. Everything was implied.

With implication came pressure. Expectations without instruction. I adapted. Again.

One afternoon, a decision landed on my desk that felt heavier than the others. It involved reallocating resources in a way that would disadvantage a smaller partner. Legal. Efficient. Unkind. The justification was simple: survival. Growth. Long-term vision. I reviewed the numbers, adjusted the language, and passed it on.

This time, the calm did not come immediately. There was a pause. A brief awareness of consequence. I thought about the partner, faceless and distant, absorbing the impact of a choice they would never trace back to me. The thought lingered longer than I expected.

Then my phone buzzed. Approval. Progress. Momentum returned.

At home, my mother asked if I was eating properly. I said yes. My father asked about work. I said it was busy. Both answers were true. Both were incomplete.

I began to notice what I no longer noticed. The hours. The tone of my own voice. The way I interrupted people more confidently. The way I listened less. These were not changes anyone commented on. That was the point.

Victor Kwan appeared again in the news, attached to another expansion, another strategic move praised for its boldness. I read the article carefully this time. Between the lines, I saw the same language I used now. The same logic. The same quiet dismissal of collateral damage.

It wasn't that he was cruel. Cruelty implies emotion. This was cleaner than that.

I understood then why people said success was lonely. Not because no one was around, but because fewer things reached you. Consequences softened. Doubts delayed. Reality filtered.

The question returned, but it sounded different now.

If I were him, would I notice when it started costing too much?

I did not answer. I already knew how these things worked. Questions fade when answers threaten comfort.

Outside, Hong Kong moved as it always did, upward, inward, relentless. I stood near a window and watched the lights, feeling closer than ever to something I had once wanted desperately.

For the first time, I wondered whether wanting it had been the mistake.

No one tells you when you cross it. There is no sound, no physical sensation, no internal alarm that rings to announce you are no longer who you were. The moment passes quietly, the way important paperwork does, signed, filed, forgotten. Only later do you realize there was no copy kept for return.

The project arrived at the end of an ordinary day. That was intentional. Urgent enough to matter, late enough to reduce resistance. My manager spoke calmly, his tone neutral in the way people adopt when they already know the answer. There was a situation developing, sensitive, time-bound, requiring discretion. He did not use words like *risk* or *loss*. He spoke instead of *alignment* and *exposure*. Vocabulary does a lot of moral labor if you let it.

The issue involved a public disclosure that could destabilize investor confidence. The information was accurate. That was the problem. If released immediately, it would complicate negotiations already in motion. If delayed, the outcome would improve. For some. Not for all.

"What we're suggesting," he said, *"is timing."*

Timing is a respectable concept. It implies intelligence. Strategy. Foresight. No one objects to timing unless they are the ones being timed against.

I reviewed the documents carefully. I asked the right questions. I confirmed legality. Everything was clean. Technically. The delay would not be permanent. Just long enough for things to settle. Long enough for decisions to be made elsewhere. Long enough for responsibility to become diffuse.

"This is common," my manager added, as if reading my hesitation. *"And reversible."*

Reversible is another comforting word. It suggests control.

I thought about refusing. Not seriously, just enough to feel honest. Refusal would not have ended my career. Not immediately. It would have marked me, though. As cautious. As unreliable under pressure. As someone who still believed in absolutes. Those labels follow you quietly.

I approved the delay.

There it was. The transaction. No witnesses. No applause. Just a click, a confirmation, a shared understanding that did not need to be spoken aloud. My manager thanked me without enthusiasm. Trust, once given, does not need celebration.

On the train home, I waited again for guilt. This time it came, briefly, like a flicker. Not overwhelming. Just enough to be inconvenient. I acknowledged it, the way you acknowledge a mild headache, and moved on. The city did not respond. The lights stayed on. People continued living.

The following days were productive. Too productive. Things moved faster once the uncertainty was removed. Decisions were made. Approvals granted. Momentum restored. I was included in conversations that assumed my agreement before I spoke. My input was sought, not questioned. Predictability had paid off.

Money followed. Not dramatically. Respectably. Enough to upgrade small things without discussion. Enough to make my parents relax in ways they did not comment on. My mother bought something unnecessary and smiled apologetically. My father stopped scanning prices at the grocery store. These changes were quiet victories. They mattered more than promotions.

Victor Kwan crossed my mind less frequently then. Not because he mattered less, but because he felt less distant. I had stopped asking what he would do. I was doing it.

One evening, I received a message from someone I hadn't spoken to in years. A former classmate. He mentioned a company he was working with, small, ambitious, struggling. He asked if I could "take a look" at something. Advice. Insight. I read his message twice before responding.

I declined politely.

I told myself I didn't have time. This was true. I told myself my involvement wouldn't change much. Also true. What I did not say, even to myself, was that helping him would have complicated things. Introduced unnecessary friction. And friction was something I was learning to avoid.

After I sent the message, I felt something tighten. Not regret. Recognition.

At work, the delayed disclosure eventually surfaced. Quietly. Buried under other announcements. The reaction was mild. Controlled. The outcome favored us. I watched the news coverage without expression. The story had been managed effectively. That was the phrase used internally.

That night, I stood by the window longer than usual. Hong Kong stretched out below, vast and indifferent. Somewhere in the city, people were absorbing consequences they would never connect to me. The thought arrived without accusation, which made it harder to dismiss.

This was the price.

Not guilt. Not punishment. Distance.

I had gained efficiency, access, momentum. In exchange, something small but essential had stepped aside. It did not leave. It simply stopped insisting on being heard. I understood then how people lived with this. How they slept. How they justified. How they continued.

The question returned one last time, altered beyond recognition.

If I were him... would I even notice the cost anymore?

The answer came easily.

No.

And that, more than anything else, frightened me.

ACT III
ARRIVAL

Success does not announce itself the way failure does. There is no single moment where you realize you have crossed into it. No applause. No clear threshold. One day, you simply notice that certain worries no longer visit you, and that their absence has not brought the peace you were promised.

I realized I had arrived on a Tuesday. Nothing special about it. No deal closed, no headline earned. I was sitting in a meeting room that looked identical to every other meeting room I had ever been in, listening to people defer to my opinion without checking whether I deserved it. They waited for me to speak. When I did, they wrote things down.

That was new.

My title had changed recently. Slightly more impressive words, rearranged carefully. My salary followed, adjusted enough to be mentioned politely but not celebrated. The kind of increase that signals trust, not generosity. I accepted it without excitement. Excitement would have been unprofessional.

Life outside work adjusted itself accordingly. I moved closer to the center. The apartment was smaller, quieter, more expensive. The view was better, which meant less of the city and more of the illusion that I was above it. I told myself it was practical. Everything I did now had a practical explanation.

My parents visited once. My mother commented on how clean everything was. My father looked out the window and said it was “convenient.” They stayed for tea, not long enough to settle. They were proud. I could tell. Pride, however, has a way of flattening conversation. There was less to ask, less to worry about. Stability had solved the visible problems.

At work, my days filled themselves. Meetings led to more meetings. Decisions stacked neatly on top of each other. I was no longer reacting; I was shaping. This felt important. Necessary. I told myself this was what competence looked like.

But relief never came.

Instead, there was a low-grade tension I could not place. Not stress, I handled stress well now. This was something else. A constant awareness that I was maintaining a version of myself that required upkeep. The clothes, the tone, the controlled patience. None of it was difficult. That was what bothered me.

I noticed how I spoke to people I once would have listened to more carefully. How quickly I dismissed concerns that complicated timelines. How easily I accepted explanations that benefited me. These changes did not feel like corruption. They felt like efficiency. That distinction mattered.

Victor Kwan appeared again, this time in person, briefly. A larger meeting. A broader table. He spoke less than most people in the room. When he did, the conversation recalibrated itself around him. He did not need to assert authority. Authority assumed him.

I watched him closely then, not with admiration, but with curiosity. He looked tired. Not visibly, just around the edges. Like someone who had not been surprised in a long time. When the meeting ended, people lingered, hoping to be noticed. Victor left early.

For a moment, I imagined following him. Asking something honest. Something impractical. I didn't. That would have been inappropriate.

On the way home, the city looked the same as it always had. Busy. Bright. Indifferent. I realized I had stopped looking at it with expectation. Hong Kong was no longer something to conquer or escape. It was infrastructure. A system I understood well enough to navigate without thinking.

That should have felt like mastery.

Instead, it felt like enclosure.

At night, I slept easily. Too easily. No scrolling. No rehearsing conversations. No imagining alternate outcomes. My mind had learned what to ignore. This was progress, according to everyone who mattered.

Sometimes, though, in the quiet between sleep and waking, something surfaced. A memory of who I was before things made sense. Before alignment replaced curiosity. Before silence felt safer than questions. The memory never stayed long. I had meetings in the morning.

I thought then, briefly, of the people I had outpaced. Friends who were still waiting. Partners absorbed quietly. Choices deferred because they complicated things. None of them haunted me. That was the most telling part.

Success had not changed my life dramatically. It had simply narrowed it.

The question I once asked, *If I were him*, no longer appeared. Not because it had been answered, but because it was no longer relevant. I wasn't trying to become someone else anymore. I had become a version of myself that fit.

And fitting, I was learning, was its own kind of disappearance.

You don't meet people like Victor Kwan by accident. Even when the encounter is unplanned, it has been prepared for you in advance, by schedules, assistants, priorities that align just long enough. When it finally happened, it felt less like an introduction and more like confirmation.

It was after a long meeting that produced exactly the outcome everyone expected and pretended was still under discussion. People gathered their things slowly, hoping proximity might turn into relevance. Victor remained seated, reviewing something on his tablet, expression unreadable in a way that had clearly been practiced. Someone said my name. Someone else gestured. And just like that, I was standing close enough to be acknowledged.

He looked at me properly this time. Not evaluating, categorizing. The look lasted a second longer than necessary.

"You've been handling the regional alignment," he said. Not a question.

"Yes," I replied. I didn't explain further. Explanation invites correction.

He nodded once. *"It's been efficient."*

Efficient. That word again. It followed me everywhere now, like a compliment that refused to deepen.

We spoke for less than two minutes. About nothing personal. About projections, timing, risk tolerance. He spoke in short sentences, never wasting emphasis. There was no warmth in him, but no cruelty either. He wasn't distant. He was contained.

When it ended, he moved on without ceremony. I stood there for a moment, then returned to collecting my things like everyone else. The room slowly emptied. No one mentioned the exchange directly. They didn't need to.

On the way home, I felt strangely calm. Not exhilarated. Not proud. Just... settled. Meeting Victor Kwan hadn't changed anything. That was the point. He wasn't a destination. He was a state.

I realized then how much of him I had projected over the years. My fear. My longing. My excuses. Standing near him had stripped all that away. He wasn't extraordinary. He was consistent. Relentlessly so. Every sharp edge sanded down in the name of continuity.

That night, I thought about his life the way one thinks about architecture. Impressive. Durable. Not designed for comfort.

Over the following weeks, I noticed how often his name surfaced as justification. *"Kwan would agree."* *"This is aligned with Kwan's approach."* He had become less a person and more a direction. That was real power, not presence, but precedent.

I caught myself using his logic without referencing him. That was when I understood I no longer needed the comparison. The idea of him had dissolved into my own decisions. I wasn't imitating anymore. I was operating.

At home, my parents called less frequently. Not because we were distant, but because there was less to worry about. Concern had been replaced with quiet pride. Conversations shortened. They asked if I was well. I said yes. We believed each other.

One weekend, I visited the old neighborhood. Nothing had changed and everything had. The buildings looked smaller. The streets louder. I passed places where I used to wait, bus stops, cafés, corners where time felt heavy. I felt nothing nostalgic. Just observant.

I wondered, briefly, what it would be like to explain my current life to the version of myself who had lived here. I decided against it. He wouldn't understand. Or worse, he would.

The thought followed me longer than I expected.

Back at work, another decision landed on my desk. Larger than the last. Cleaner. Final. I handled it without pause. That frightened me more than hesitation ever had. Ease is a dangerous indicator.

That evening, I stood by the window again. Same city. Same lights. Different distance. I thought of Victor, not as an idol, not as a warning, but as a possible ending. Not tragic. Not glorious. Just quiet.

For the first time, I asked a different question.

If this is where the path leads... why did I want it so badly?

The answer did not come. Answers require space. I had filled mine carefully over the years, leaving no room for them to arrive.

The city does not care how your story ends. Hong Kong continues whether you arrive or disappear, whether you rise or stall. That was the first lesson it taught me, and the last one I needed to remember.

I stood in my apartment one morning, looking at a view I had once wanted badly. The glass was clean. The room was quiet. Everything worked the way it was supposed to. This, I knew, was what success looked like when it stopped trying to impress anyone. Efficient. Stable. Finished.

My phone buzzed with messages I would respond to later. Meetings waited. Decisions stacked patiently. I had become reliable, which is another word people use when they no longer worry about you changing.

There was no regret. That surprised me. Regret would have implied a mistake, and nothing about my journey had been accidental. Every choice had made sense at the time. Every compromise had arrived with logic, not force. I had agreed willingly. That was the truth most people avoid.

I visited my parents that weekend. We ate quietly. My mother asked about work. My father listened. Neither of them needed details anymore. They were proud in the way people are when anxiety finally loosens its grip. I did not correct them. Pride, like relief, deserves to exist undisturbed.

When I left, my mother reminded me to take care of myself. I promised I would. The promise sounded convincing enough.

At work, someone asked me for advice. A recent graduate. Bright. Uncertain. He spoke the way I once had, carefully, politely, as if permission were required to want more. I listened. I told him what worked. I did not tell him what it cost. That omission felt intentional, not cruel.

Later that day, Victor Kwan's name appeared in another context. Not news. Not meetings. A passing reference. He had become background, which was perhaps his greatest achievement. I understood him now better than I ever had before. Not because I knew him, but because I knew the path.

We were not the same person. That was never the point.

I went home earlier than usual. The city was loud, alive, indifferent. I watched people move with urgency I no longer felt. I had stopped chasing. I had arrived somewhere that did not require motion to maintain.

That night, I opened my laptop and scrolled without intention. Not looking for opportunity. Not measuring myself against others. Just observing. The quiet felt unfamiliar. Almost intrusive.

I realized then that the question which had shaped so much of my life, *If I were him*, had finally lost its grip. Not because it had been answered, but because it was no longer necessary.

I had learned something more precise.

Becoming someone else is easy. You just have to agree often enough.

What's difficult is noticing what leaves while you're busy becoming.

I turned off the light and lay in the dark, listening to the city breathe. I did not feel empty. I did not feel complete. I felt aware.

And that, finally, was enough.

THE END

X

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